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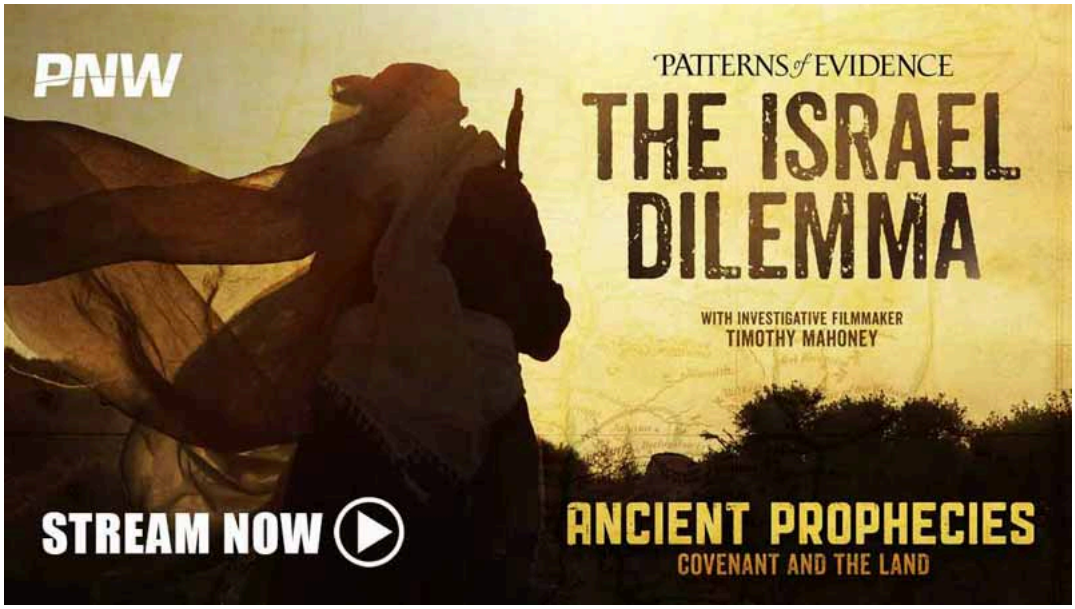

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ARTICLE

Record 'Nones' In America - Could War Trigger A Spiritual Awakening?

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BY PNW STAFF MARCH 11, 2026

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A generation that once felt it could live comfortably without faith may suddenly be rediscovering just how fragile the world really is.

For decades, sociologists have tracked a quiet but dramatic shift in American life. Religion -- once the beating heart of communities across the country -- has slowly been moving to the margins. The latest numbers suggest that trend has now reached a historic milestone.

According to new data from Gallup, Americans with no formal religious identity -- often called the "nones" -- now make up 24% of the U.S. population, the highest level ever recorded. Just a few generations ago, that number was almost unimaginable. In 1948, only 2% of Americans identified this way.

At the same time, the poll reveals another striking reality: only 47% of Americans say religion is "very important" in their lives. That number once stood between 70% and 75% during the 1950s and 1960s, a time when faith shaped not just private belief but the moral vocabulary of the entire nation.

Today, the landscape looks very different. Millions of Americans describe themselves as spiritual but not religious, skeptical of organized religion, or simply indifferent. For many, life feels busy, comfortable, and stable enough that deeper spiritual questions can wait.

But history has a way of interrupting that sense of security.

And as tensions rise in the Middle East -- particularly with the growing conflict involving Iran -- the world suddenly feels far less predictable than it did just a few years ago.

Moments like this often awaken questions people thought they had moved beyond.

The #1 Olive Oil For Drinking

Here are ten reasons why the rise of global uncertainty may lead some of the "nones" to reconsider their spiritual outlook.

1. War Has a Way of Reminding Us How Fragile Life Really Is

Most of us live day-to-day assuming tomorrow will look much like today. We plan vacations, build careers, raise families, and assume the world will keep humming along.

War shatters that illusion.

When nations move toward conflict, when energy markets shake, and when headlines carry the language of missiles and mobilization, we're reminded of something humanity has always known but often tries to forget: life is fragile. In those moments, the question of whether there is something -- or Someone -- beyond this world suddenly feels far more important.

2. The Darkness of Human Nature Becomes Harder to Ignore

Modern culture often teaches that people are basically good and that progress will eventually smooth out the rough edges of history.

Yet war keeps exposing something darker.

Nations still threaten each other. Leaders gamble with lives. Violence erupts even in an age of incredible education and technological progress.

Christianity has always explained this reality through the idea of a fallen human nature -- that something deep inside us is broken. When conflict erupts again and again despite humanity's progress, that ancient explanation begins to feel less like theology and more like simple honesty.

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3. Crisis Has Always Sparked Spiritual Searching

History shows that when the ground begins to shake beneath society, people instinctively start searching for something deeper.

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Comfort often dulls spiritual curiosity. Crisis tends to awaken it.

4. The Middle East Keeps Pulling the World Back

Many Americans rarely think about the Middle East -- until suddenly it dominates every headline.

Conflicts involving Iran, Israel, and neighboring nations seem to pull global attention back to the same region again and again.

For Christians, that reality carries another layer of meaning. Much of the Bible's history -- and many of its prophetic passages, including those in the book of Ezekiel -- revolve around this very region. Even those who once dismissed such discussions may find themselves wondering whether history has deeper patterns than we once assumed.

5. War Forces Us to Talk About Right and Wrong Again

In peaceful times, it's easy to believe that morality is simply a matter of personal opinion.

But war doesn't allow that luxury.

When nations invade, when civilians are threatened, and when global leaders debate justice and retaliation, people instinctively start speaking in moral terms again. Words like evil, justice, and responsibility return to public conversation.

And those words have always lived most naturally inside a moral framework shaped by faith.

6. Politics Suddenly Looks Smaller Than We Thought

Many Americans have placed enormous faith in political systems to solve humanity's problems.

Yet time and again, global conflict reminds us that governments are limited. Diplomacy fails. Alliances fracture. Leaders make decisions that send shockwaves around the world.

When political solutions fall short, people often begin asking whether something greater must ultimately anchor hope.

7. The Questions We Tried to Ignore Come Back

When the world feels safe, it's easy to push aside life's biggest questions.

Wh

Is h

Is there a God guiding the story of humanity?

But when the future suddenly feels uncertain, those questions come rushing back.

Many "nones" may not have rejected these questions as much as they simply postponed them.

8. Faith Communities Offer Something Modern Culture Often Cannot

One thing crises reveal is how deeply people need community.

Churches and faith groups historically become places where people gather, pray, share resources, and comfort one another during uncertain times. They provide meaning when headlines feel overwhelming.

In a culture that increasingly celebrates individualism, that kind of spiritual community can suddenly feel incredibly valuable.

9. The World Still Revolves Around a Very Ancient Story

Despite all our technological advancement, humanity still finds itself drawn back to the same ancient lands and conflicts that shaped biblical history.

That alone doesn't prove anything spiritually. But it does raise a fascinating question: why does so much of world history keep circling back to the very places Scripture placed at the center of its story?

For some observers, that question alone is enough to spark deeper curiosity.

10. Crisis Reveals the Limits of a Material-Only Life

Modern culture has largely promised that happiness comes through comfort, success, and technological progress.

Yet war reminds us how quickly those things can shake. Markets fall. Energy supplies tighten. Stability suddenly looks far less permanent.

When the foundations of everyday life begin to tremble, people often rediscover something their grandparents understood well: material success alone cannot answer the deepest questions of the human heart.

The rise of the "nones" tells an important story about modern America. Many people have drifted away from organized religion, often quietly and gradually.

But history suggests something else as well.

Moments of global uncertainty have a way of reopening spiritual conversations that once seemed settled.

And as the world watches tensions involving Iran unfold, millions of Americans who once felt comfortable living without faith may find themselves asking an unexpected question again:

What if the spiritual questions we set aside were actually the most important ones all along?

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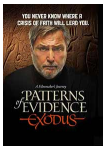

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